

Day : 6

Essay

Q

"The demand of smaller states reflect both democratic aspiration and administrative desperation." Critically examine this ~~examir~~ statement in the light of India's Federal structure, regional inequalities and cultural diversity [50M]

→

India is a multi-linguistic, multi-ethnic nation enriched with social fabric. This Diversity is an asset that promotes cultural vibrancy. But at the same time it poses challenge of confrontation. So, to create a fine balance between the asset and the challenge, Our Constitution has adopted a ~~It makes Division of power by Constitution and the~~ sui-generis model of federalism. However, the debate for creation of smaller states reflects both democratic aspiration and administrative desperation.

1.

Federal structure of India

Federalism establishes a division of powers between different levels of government ensuring autonomy in their sphere. It reflects the principle of shared sovereignty, wherein

each level of government derives its authority from the Constitution itself.

- The demand for smaller states has emerged as a recurring theme, raising question about governance, and the regional aspirations in India.

~~Reasons behind demand of smaller states.~~

The Indian Federalism accommodates such demands, creating a balance between regional autonomy and National unity.

### (i) Internal Restructuring

- Article 3 of the Indian Constitution empowers the parliament to reorganise state boundaries, create state by separating from existing states.

### (ii) Various forms of Federalism

- To maintain the diversity and political commitment, Indian Federalism has evolved with time :-

#### (a) Cooperative Federalism

- State and centre work together to achieve a common national goals.
- NITI Aayog promotes cooperative federalism emphasising bottom-up planning where states' needs and priorities

## (b) Competitive Federalism

- Different states compete with each other for improved governance and delivery of better services.

## (c) Fiscal Federalism

- Division of financial powers and responsibilities between different levels of government.
- With the recommendations of Finance Commission, the central ~~tax~~ taxes are devolved to the states.

## (d) Asymmetrical Federalism

- Different states or regions enjoy different degree of autonomy in their sphere.
- Article 371 (A to J) provides special provisions to several states.

## (e) Political Federalism

- A balance of political power between the centre and the states.

## (f) Green Federalism

- Nature is seen not just as a resource but as a contributor to the economy.
- Finance commission incorporates parameters such as forest cover in its devolution formula.

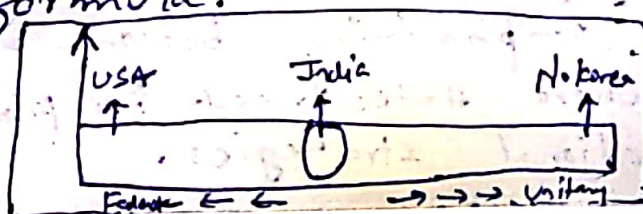


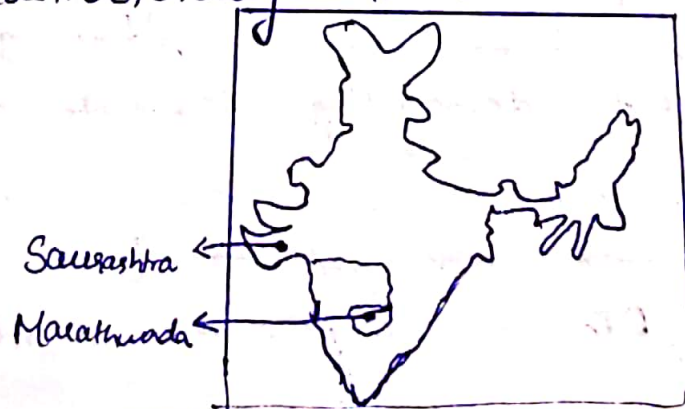
Fig: Federal to Unitary Spectrum

## Comparison of India's Federal structure with USA

| Feature          | India                                          | USA                                    |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Term used        | Union of states                                | Perfect Union                          |
| Formation        | Centralized authority, states created by union | Agreement among states                 |
| Boundary Changes | Flexible ; Parliament can alter                | Rigid, state consent is required       |
| Secession        | Not allowed                                    | Historically possible (Ex:- civil war) |

## 2. Regional inequalities

- Regional imbalances in the development have often become a source of discontent, leading to demand of separate statehood.
- Places like Marathwada and Vidarbha in Maharashtra and Saurashtra in Gujarat are the prominent example.
- Despite being part of relatively developed states, these regions have remained economically and infrastructurally backward.



## (i) Infrastructure prioritization

- Focusing on Neglected areas : Smaller administrative units prioritize development of peripheral regions.
- Balanced Growth : Ensures equitable infrastructure development.

## 3. ~~Cultural Diversity~~

### (i) Economic optimization

- (a) Resource Utilization : Small states can focus on natural and human resources optimization, aligning with regional economic priorities.

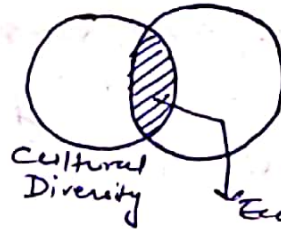
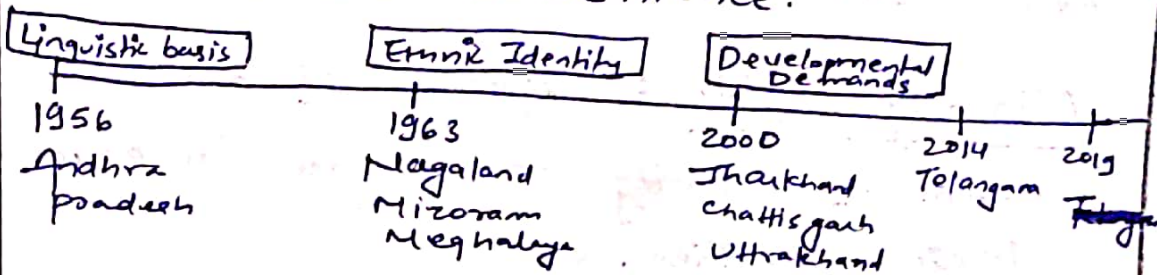
(b) Industry - specific Growth

- Geo-economic alignment, encouraging Industrial specialization.
- Ex:- Jharkhand's focus on mining industries & shows how smaller states can capitalize on localized resources.

### 3. Cultural Diversity

- After independence, voices pitched for the demand of state on linguistic identity.
- The second phase emerged when ethnic, tribal and cultural groups started demanding separate statehood.
- Then later on, a new rationale developed emerged to form states on economic development and

# administrative Convenience.



Ex:- Bodoland  
Gorkhaland  
Ladakh  
Mithankot

(i)

## Asymmetrical Federalism

Certain regions are given special autonomy who feel neglected or distinct to demand for a separate state.

Schedule V and VI : Offer special protections to tribal areas and in North East through Autonomous District Councils.

(ii)

~~Ethnic Identity~~

## Article 371 (A to J) : Special

provisions to specific states like Nagaland, Mizoram, Andhra Pradesh to safeguard their cultural, economic and administrative uniqueness.

(iii)

## Ethnic Identity

:- Ethnic groups with distinct traditions, language and history demand for separate statehood.

Ex:- Bodoland, Gorkhaland, Purnanchal

(iv) Minority rights : Article 29 and 30  
empower minority communities to preserve their identities.

- Forest rights Act, (2006) recognizes the rights of forest-dwelling Scheduled Tribes and forest dwellers.

So, India's secular ethos guarantees equal treatment to all religions.

(v) Linguistic Basis :- Language is not only a means of communication but it's also a descriptive identity.  
The first state to be formed on language basis was Andhra Pradesh (1953).

### Challenges

(i) Administrative Proliferation  
Creation of new states result in increased cost and hinders efficiency in multi layered administration.

(ii) Political Balkanisation  
It can lead to political atomization, weakening National unity.

(iii) Resource Disputes  
Dividing states often lead to dispute over water, energy and minerals.

(iv)

## Precedential Domino Effect

Statehood demand sets a precedent to encourage territorial divisions.

### Way Forward

(i)

Comprehensive Legislative Framework for state Reorganization.

(ii)

Regional Councils for Transitional Autonomy

(iii)

Geoeconomic Mapping

(iv)

Conflict Resolution Mechanism for Resource sharing.

The journey of state formation in India reflects the dynamic nature of its federal structure. Balancing regional aspirations with national integrity is a delicate act. Embracing India's diversity and ensuring its unity remains intact is a thoughtful and inclusive approach to transform challenges into opportunities.